

HENRY VIII'S SIX WIVES

1509–1533

Catherine of Aragon, Henry's first wife, gives birth six times but only one child—Mary (later Mary I)—survives infancy. Henry annuls (cancels) their marriage in search of a male heir.

1533–1536

While Henry's marriage to Anne Boleyn produces the future Queen Elizabeth I, he has her executed when she does not produce a son.



ANNE BOLEYN

1536–1537

Jane Seymour bears Henry a male heir to the throne, and is the only queen to do so. She dies shortly after their son Edward is born.

1540

The fourth woman to marry Henry is German-born Anne of Cleves. Their marriage is annulled after just six months.

1540–1542

Catherine Howard, Henry VIII's fifth wife, suffers the same fate as Anne Boleyn. She is beheaded after she fails to bear him children during the two years of their marriage.

1543–1547

Catherine Parr outlives Henry but dies soon after him in 1548. She writes a prayer book, becoming the first woman in England to publish a book in English under her own name.

CATHERINE
PARR'S PRAYERS
OR MEDITATIONS

The Tudors

The rule of the Tudor Dynasty began in 1485 when Henry Tudor seized the throne of England by defeating King Richard III of the rival Yorkist Dynasty in battle, and became Henry VII. The Tudors reigned for more than a century, until the death of Elizabeth I in 1603. During this period, England grew in power and influence, becoming richer than ever before, and enjoyed an unprecedented flowering of culture and the arts.

The Tudors introduced important changes that impacted all areas of life in England. Wary of Yorkist rebellions, Henry VII (reigned 1485–1509) seized their lands and strengthened the power of the monarchy.

His successor, Henry VIII (reigned 1509–1547) removed the authority of the Catholic Church, appointing himself the leader of a new Church of England, which preached a form of Christianity known as Protestantism. He also built up the Royal Navy to become one of the most powerful naval forces in English history. Henry

was succeeded by three of his children in turn—Edward VI in 1547, Mary I in 1553, and Elizabeth I in 1558.

Elizabeth I was a strong ruler, and during her reign England emerged as a major power, rivaling Spain for dominance in Europe. Elizabeth's reign was also an age of international expansion, as explorers and merchants ventured to the Americas and set up colonies. Education improved and the arts flourished, too, especially the theater. Despite this, many people lived in poverty and struggled to afford food and clothing.

◀ HENRY VIII

Although English monarchs ruled their own land, they were answerable to the supreme authority of the Pope in Rome. When the Pope refused to allow Henry VIII to divorce his first wife, Henry cut ties with the Catholic Church. He went on to close England's monasteries, seizing their lands and wealth for himself. Although intelligent and cultured, Henry was a cruel king and had two of his six wives executed.



The globe represents England's dominance in overseas trade and exploration.

